3. Buy a multiple-unit dwelling

There's a reason this strategy is popular . . . someone else is paying your mortgage. It doesn't get any better than that. Ideally, you'll want a positive cash flow with the building so that the loss of a job or family health crisis does not have to mean the loss of a roof over your head. However, even if you only break even, you are still not paying rent. Of course, upkeep is still yours, as are any insurance considerations. This is a great way for young people with good credit but lower income to get into the game and start moving ahead. Word to the wise: Whenever we have looked into these income buildings in the past the rule of thumb we were given was that anything up to a four-plex was considered residential, which means that you'll get the residential rate when borrowing money. Five units and above fall into the commercial category, so you'll get charged higher interest rates.

4. Use your job's housing allowance

If your job comes with a housing allowance (and many do), purchase a house in a price range that will cause the payments to fall within your monthly allotment. If possible, try to purchase in an area with great annual value increases. When the time comes, sell the house. If you have a profit (and most likely you will if you shopped wisely to begin with), great. If not, and you just break even, at least you'll get a retroactive reimbursement of your living expenses. Yes, you have to wait for the return on this. And yes, you have to shop wisely up front. But how many landlords have you rented from who will refund your rent after you move out?

5. Pay cash

Yes, this can be done. Granted, for those without a trust fund (which is most of us), it requires the advance use of strategies such as numbers 1–4, but it *is* achievable. If you've been saving for a while and your income is not dependent on a particular location, consider purchasing a more rural property. You can oftentimes get more bang for your real estate buck this way, and actually have a shot at things you want early on in the game. Maybe not the first purchase of a home, but certainly by the second it is possible to get things like more acreage, waterfront, or a small hobby farm type of property for the kids to enjoy.

6. Live in a yurt

Contrary to the belief of uninformed individuals, these structures are *way*